



THE BATTERY BLUES

Kimi Antonelli and George Russell have delivered the pace, but battery glitches and mechanical gremlins are **threatening to derail** Mercedes' championship charge.

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When George Russell and Kimi Antonelli locked out the front row of the grid during qualifying ahead of the season opener in Australia in March, things looked ominous.

Two teammates qualifying alongside each other is not exactly rare. However, the eight-tenths and five-tenths gaps to the third-placed driver indicated that Mercedes might have a smooth path to Drivers' and Constructors' championships in

2026. But the ensuing season has been anything but plain sailing for the Silver Arrows. Despite its edge in pace over its nearest rivals, the Brackley-based team is yet to translate that into a points advantage, especially in the Drivers' Championship. The goddess of luck has turned her face away on multiple occasions this season.

Nineteen-year-old Antonelli has undoubtedly been the standout driver this season. His victory in the Belgian Grand Prix this week was his sixth of the season. But two non-point finishes in the last four races mean the Italian remains

within touching distance of the rest of the pack. Last time out at Silverstone, Antonelli suffered a tyre shield failure that affected the car's steering. A subsequent penalty for repeatedly exceeding track limits in a damaged car pushed him out of the points and allowed teammate Russell to close the gap.

At Spa-Francorchamps, it was Russell's turn to be deserted by luck. The Briton started well off the line but lost multiple places on the **Kemmel Straight.** He then tangled with the Ferrari of Lewis Hamilton and found himself beached in the gravel trap, causing his second